

Wat Pong Kham Learning Center

Community Learning Promotion Foundation · Du Phong, Santisuk District, Nan

Forest, farm and Dhamma — Buddhist agriculture for the well-being of farmers and forests

Background

Travelling across Nan Province offers sweeping views of rolling mountains, and that is the problem: few trees now block the view. Nan had some of the worst deforestation in Thailand. Its forests declined by about a third between 2000 and 2012, even as forest cover was recovering elsewhere in the country. Around 80% of the province is classified as protected land, yet only about 14% of its people hold title to the land they farm.

Without secure tenure, farmers plant maize on hillsides: it grows fast, needs no long-term investment and sells well. Companies supply seed and agrochemicals on credit, repaid at harvest. When crops fall short of company standards, farmers fall into debt and clear more forest. Bare slopes bring erosion, chemicals in the streams, worse floods and harsher droughts. Poverty, household debt and labour migration follow.

Wat Pong Kham stands in Du Phong sub-district, Santisuk district. Its abbot, Phrakhru Sujinnanthakit (Somkit Jaranathammo), traces deforestation and debt to greed and delusion and answers with what he calls **dhammic agriculture**: farming on a Dhamma basis that joins Buddhist ethics to scientific knowledge and market strategy. Since 1992 the temple has been a community learning centre, and since 2008 a registered foundation at the hub of a network of organic community enterprises.

NAN AT A GLANCE

~33%	~80%	~14%	~50
decline in Nan's forests, 2000–2012	of the province classified as protected land	of Nan's people hold title to their land	farmers in Somkit's cooperative (2019)





Origins of the Learning Center

A monk from a farming family

Phrakhru Somkit grew up in Pong Kham and was ordained as a novice at 12. He saw his own family's livelihood change. In the early 1980s, after the communist insurgency ended, his father was among the first in the village to give up upland subsistence farming for maize. As for many families, prosperity did not follow: crops often failed company standards, debts mounted, and more forest was cleared.

Learning from other monks

In the early 1990s, Somkit joined Phrakhru Pithak Nanthakhun of nearby Ban Kiw Mueang, his teacher and some fifteen years his senior. Pithak performed Nan's first tree ordination and founded the Hug Mueang Nan network. Somkit was also inspired by Phrakhru Manas of Phayao, pioneer of tree ordination. Alongside his monastic career he earned a bachelor's degree and a master's in Man and Environment Management at Chiang Mai University (2005), a scientific grounding that helps him work with NGOs and state agencies.

Three stages of activism

Somkit describes his work in three stages. The first, beginning in the 1980s and 1990s, aimed to preserve the forest. The second in the 2000s fought debt through village savings funds: "Still, we couldn't stop the debt." The third in the 2010s is dhammic agriculture, which goes beyond subsistence: farmers should "grow less but gain more", focusing on quality so that consumers want their produce.

A drop of dye in clear water

From 1997 to 2015 (B.E. 2540–2558), Somkit watched with growing unease as maize spread across Nan. He also saw monks' standing decline, as development came to mean money, degrees and official endorsement, leaving monks only to look after the temple as a "bridge of merit". Yet the Buddha called the Sangha the world's field of merit, meant to relieve physical and mental suffering. In the name of development, he argues, farming was pulled away from the Dhamma and reduced to "whoever does more gets more", forgetting that doing more also destroys more. His answer was to start small, where the problem lies, and let the example spread.

Farming is unusual for a monk, as the monastic rules forbid digging the soil. Somkit sees caring for land as part of relieving suffering, while remaining a "field of merit" through which villagers make merit.

> ***"We might ask to be a dye, a primary colour dripped into water. Even if it is only a tiny drop, it will gradually spread and may turn clear water into coloured water."***
>
> *Phrakhru Somkit, on starting small*

A hat for the mountain, shoes for its foot

The project "Putting a Hat on the Mountain, Putting Shoes on the Foot of the Hill" (Suam muak hai phukhao, suam rongthao hai tin doi), i.e. restoring forest cover on the hilltops (the "hat") while farming the lower slopes and foothills (the "shoes") grew from lessons learned on forest walks: start from a small problem spot, then expand.

Around 1991 Somkit adapted the traditional Phra Phaa offering: instead of goods, he asked villagers to give trees, and replanted the maize fields behind the temple, turning it into a forest temple (wat pa). In the mid-1990s his father gave him a worn-out maize plot as an act of merit. Left fallow for about ten years, it became lush forest again, rich in plants and animals. People said the monk had gone on bindabat, the morning alms round, for land, and other villagers began to donate land too.

WAT PONG KHAM AT A GLANCE

1992 community learning centre set up at the temple	**2008** Community Learning Promotion Foundation registered	**29** communities in the temple's network	**3** temples following the Wat Pong Kham model

The Temple, Forest, and Farm

Rituals for forest and river

Eco-Buddhism is woven with ritual: tree ordinations (buat pa), life-prolonging ceremonies for rivers (suep chata mae nam), and "alms-requesting" of forest, in which land is asked back from farming and returned to forest.

Somkit links Buddhist teaching with local belief: "good soil is protected by a beneficent spirit, Mae Thoranee, goddess of earth … Good water is protected by the water goddess, Phramae Khong Kha." People honour these spirits and care for what they protect. For Somkit the forest "is essentially a part of life", providing water, soil, food and knowledge.

THE FOUR HOUSEHOLDER VIRTUES

Dhammic agriculture applies the four values the Buddha taught for lay householders (gharavasa-dhamma): honesty, tolerance, patience and sharing. Through them, Somkit argues, farmers can move from capitalist to dhammic agriculture.

Integrated farming

Visitors may think they are still walking through woods until fruit trees wrapped in pea vines come into view. Integrated agriculture (kaset phasom phasaan) mimics nature: plants that help each other grow together, fish live in ponds, and chickens roam freely, eating insects and fallen fruit. The farm shows intensive planting on a small plot, with trellises around fishponds whose water and plants nourish the crops.

Member farmers have moved from maize to mixed organic vegetables grown in greenhouses with drip irrigation and compost: Chinese cabbage, choy sum, baby bok choy, Japanese cucumber, tomato, pea aubergine, pumpkin, passion fruit, ginger, galangal and lemongrass. Low costs, a secure buyer and a steady income are what make the system work for them.

Marketing on a Dhamma basis

Farmers always ask: who will buy it? Somkit uses faith as a marketing lever. Giving talks in other provinces, he took along a tonne or two of unsold produce: "People without merit will not get the chance to eat this produce." It sold out. The foundation now collects members' vegetables, sold through retailers as "morality vegetables of Wat Pong Kham" under the slogan "Love Nan, love the forest, love water, love life".

A foundation and an enterprise network

The Community Learning Promotion Foundation (Wat Pong Kham) works on three principles: farming based on community needs, business on a Dhamma basis, and a network of community enterprises. Because the monk's group was dismissed as unofficial, members registered as community enterprises and joined a participatory (PGS) organic network. Somkit became its chair, the first monk in Thailand to chair a community enterprise. Shared rules stress honesty, patience, self-reliance, sacrifice, sharing and, above all, action.

A Sufficiency Economy model

The temple also applies the Sufficiency Economy model of King Rama IX: moderation, reasonableness and self-immunity, built on knowledge and virtue, adapted to local conditions. As a learning centre, the temple works in four dimensions:

1. **Economic** — upland crops, small intensive plots instead of maize, ponds and water systems, greenhouses, processing, local seed saving
2. **Social** — cooperation between home, temple and school, farmer-group development, networks inside and outside the village
3. **Environmental** — restoration and conservation, and a network to monitor and report local problems
4. **Cultural** — village festivals, a community-history curriculum, and the temple as a cultural learning site

TURNING CAPITAL INTO DHAMMA

Dhamma as the base: nature, the Buddha's teaching and local ways of life.

Work as capital: grouping, joint activities, networks and shared planning.

Merit as the goal: diligence, honesty, generosity and love of one's homeland.





Activities and Training Content

Partners and the royal network

The temple works with many partners from farming communities, civil society organizations, private sector and government agencies. A Royal Project supplies greenhouse plastic and seeds and buys produce. Somkit has promoted vetiver grass against erosion, advised the Phu Fa royal project in Bo Kluea, and since 2009 has served as an adviser to the Phid Thong Lang Phra royal project for the upper Nan basin.

Current challenges

Uptake in the home village (Pong Kham) remains limited: only about 30 of 240 households belong to the organic enterprise. Many villagers understand the Sufficiency Economy but still seek cash through migrant work and monoculture, and cite lack of capital, costly fertiliser, unstable prices, too little land and water shortages. Researchers also debate the model.

Six training courses

1. **Seeds and seedlings** — raising seeds and collecting saplings
2. **Life planning** — changing mindsets, saving money and "saving life"
3. **Soil fertility** — quality organic fertiliser and bio-ferments
4. **Processing** — transforming and packaging farm produce
5. **Planning and marketing** — production plans and market access
6. **Farm management** — crop plots, livestock and fish

TIMELINE SUMMARY

Early 1980s
B.E. 2520s

Somkit's father is among the first in the village to grow maize.

Early 1990s
B.E. 2530s

Somkit joins Phrakhru Pithak; farming begin behind the temple.

1992
B.E. 2535

Wat Pong Kham becomes a community learning centre.

Mid-1990s
B.E. 2530s

Father donates a worn-out maize plot; left fallow, it returns to forest.

1997–2015
B.E. 2540–2558

Maize expands across Nan; Somkit seeks a way out.

2005
B.E. 2548

Completes his master's thesis at Chiang Mai University.

2008
B.E. 2551

Community Learning Promotion Foundation registered.

2009
B.E. 2552

Somkit advises the Phid Thong Lang Phra royal project.

2016
B.E. 2559

"Hat on the Mountain" project; enterprise network formed.

2019
B.E. 2562

About 50 farmers in the cooperative; produce sold in Bangkok.

2020
B.E. 2563

Forum on organic standards, greenhouses and marketing.

Now
Ongoing

Seeking Thai FDA approval for herbal products development.







